



ZERO PACK

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THE BRAND'S GUIDE TO Custom Compostable Packaging

A practical guide for ecommerce brands, retailers and organisations ready to replace conventional plastic packaging.

What you will find in this guide:

- What custom compostable packaging is — and how it works
- Why growing brands are moving away from conventional plastic mailers
- How to choose the right packaging format for your products
- When a business is ready to switch — and when it is not
- How to avoid greenwashing and vague packaging claims
- The commercial case for better branded packaging
- How to plan your first order: MOQ, artwork, size, and lead times
- A decision checklist, FAQ, and quote-ready prompt

Custom compostable packaging for brands that care.

Guide Snapshot: The Fast Answer

Custom compostable packaging is made-to-order packaging designed to replace conventional plastic while improving brand presentation. For most ecommerce brands, the most practical first step is a custom compostable mailer: branded, waterproof, durable, and suitable for regular dispatch.

This guide is written for brands that want a practical way to assess whether custom compostable packaging is commercially viable, operationally realistic, and credible enough to support their sustainability claims.

How to Use This Guide

Start with Sections 1 to 4 if you are still comparing packaging options. Go to Sections 7, 11, 12 and 15 if you are close to requesting a quote. Use Sections 9 and 10 before making any public environmental claims about your packaging.

Question	Fast Answer
Best first packaging format	Custom compostable mailers for regular ecommerce orders
Typical starting MOQ	Around 2,000 units, depending on product and specification
Best-fit brands	Fashion, beauty, wellness, gifts, books, stationery, soft homewares and subscription brands
Main preparation needed	Size, quantity, delivery country, artwork, colours, timeline and product details
Biggest claim risk	Using vague terms like eco-friendly, biodegradable or sustainable without certification details

Best next step

Use the quote-ready checklist and send Zero Pack the information you already have

1. Introduction: Why Packaging Matters More Than Most Brands Realise

Before your customer sees your product, they see the packaging it arrives in.

For ecommerce brands, that moment — when the parcel lands on the doorstep or arrives at a pickup point — is often the first real, physical interaction a customer has with your business after placing an order. It is the transition point between a digital transaction and a tangible brand experience.

Yet for many businesses, packaging is still treated as a cost to minimise rather than an opportunity to maximise. It is ordered in bulk from the cheapest available supplier, in a generic size, usually made of conventional plastic, and rarely given the same attention as the product it carries.

That disconnect is becoming harder to ignore.

Customers notice packaging. They form opinions from it, photograph it, talk about it, and share it. They also notice when packaging feels out of step with the product it carries — when a thoughtfully made, premium item arrives in a plain grey plastic bag, or when a brand that positions itself around quality and values ships in packaging that tells a different story.

Packaging Is Part of the Customer Experience

Custom compostable packaging is not just a sustainability decision. It is a brand, customer experience, and commercial decision at the same time.

Done well, it improves first impressions, reinforces brand perception, creates a stronger unboxing experience, and helps businesses demonstrate their values in a way that customers can see and feel directly.

This guide is designed to help you think through the full picture: what custom compostable packaging is, why brands are moving towards it, how to choose the right format, when the timing is right, and how to plan a first order without unnecessary complexity.

Whether you are currently using plain plastic mailers, recycled plastic bags, paper alternatives, or nothing branded at all, the questions and frameworks in this guide will help you decide whether custom compostable packaging is the right next step — and how to make that step with confidence.

2. Why Brands Are Moving Away From Conventional Plastic Packaging

Conventional plastic mailers have been the default for ecommerce shipping for good reason. They are inexpensive, widely available, lightweight, and functional. For many businesses, they have worked well enough for years.

But the landscape has shifted. The case for continuing to default to conventional plastic mailers is weaker than it used to be — not only because of environmental considerations, but because of commercial and customer experience pressures as well.

Customers Are More Aware of Packaging Waste

Customers are increasingly conscious of the packaging they receive. This does not mean every customer will abandon a brand over a plastic mailer. But it does mean packaging is now something customers notice, comment on, and factor into their overall impression of a business.

For brands in fashion, beauty, wellness, gifts, and lifestyle categories, this is especially relevant. These audiences tend to care about the brands they buy from. They pay attention to detail. They often share unboxing moments on social media. Packaging that feels lazy, wasteful, or out of step with the product and the brand can quietly undermine the experience the product itself was designed to create.

Plastic Packaging Can Feel Misaligned With Brand Values

Brands spend significant time and money developing their visual identity, product quality, and customer messaging. A conventional plastic mailer can unintentionally contradict all of that at the moment it matters most.

A product carefully positioned as premium, ethical, or considered arrives in packaging that communicates none of those things. For growing brands working hard to build trust and loyalty, that inconsistency is a real commercial problem.

Ecommerce Packaging Is Highly Visible

Online retail means packaging is seen far more often than in traditional retail. Every order generates a physical interaction — a touchpoint that in a physical store might have involved a branded bag, tissue paper, or at minimum a consistent shelf presentation.

In ecommerce, the mailer or outer packaging is often the only physical packaging a customer receives. It is not supplementary to the experience. It is the experience.

Growing Pressure to Make Better Choices

Businesses of all sizes are facing growing internal and external pressure to review their packaging choices. Staff, customers, media attention, retail partners, and broader cultural expectations are all pushing towards packaging that relies less on conventional plastics.

This is not necessarily about meeting a specific regulation or satisfying an auditor. For most growing brands, it is simpler than that: they want their packaging to align with what they stand for, without making the process complicated or unworkable.

What This Guide Does Not Claim

Switching to compostable packaging is not a solution to all packaging-related challenges. Compostable materials come with their own considerations around disposal, certification, and end-of-life conditions.

This guide takes a practical and honest approach. Custom compostable packaging is not perfect packaging. It is a better direction for brands that want to reduce their reliance on conventional plastic while improving how their packaging looks, feels, and performs.

3. What Is Custom Compostable Packaging?

Custom compostable packaging is packaging made from materials designed to break down under composting conditions, printed and sized to order with your brand's logo, colours, artwork, or campaign design.

There are two distinct parts to that definition worth understanding separately.

Compostable Materials

Compostable packaging is made from certified compostable material blends, which may include plant-based inputs and compostable polymers. The important point is not the marketing label alone, but whether the material has been tested against a recognised compostability standard and whether the end-of-life conditions are clearly explained.

The word 'compostable' is not interchangeable with 'biodegradable' or 'eco-friendly'. These terms mean different things, and the differences matter. This is covered in detail in Section 10 of this guide.

Custom and Branded

Custom compostable packaging is produced to your specifications. That means your logo, your brand colours, your artwork, your preferred size, and your production quantity — rather than generic stock packaging ordered off a shelf.

Custom branded packaging is not only about aesthetics. It changes what the packaging communicates. A branded custom mailer tells customers something about your business the moment it arrives. A plain generic bag does not.

Made to Order

Custom compostable packaging is produced in response to a specific order rather than held as pre-made stock. This means each production run is created to your dimensions, print specifications, and quantity requirements.

Made-to-order production has implications for lead times and minimum order quantities, both of which are covered later in this guide. The key point is that custom packaging requires planning — it is not the same as ordering a box of generic stock mailers for next-day delivery.

What Custom Compostable Packaging Is Not

- It is worth being clear about what this category of packaging does not include:
- It is not the same as standard brown kraft paper bags, which are paper-based but not necessarily certified compostable.
 - It is not the same as recycled plastic mailers, which are made from reclaimed plastic but are still plastic.
 - It is not an off-the-shelf product you can order in small quantities and receive tomorrow.
 - It is not automatically plastic-free in all senses — the material composition and certification vary depending on specification.

Material Options at a Glance

The right packaging material depends on what you are shipping, how the customer will dispose of the packaging, and what claims your brand wants to make. Use this comparison as a starting point, not as a substitute for checking the exact material specification.

Material / Format	Best For	Main Strength	Main Watch-Out
Certified compostable film	Mailers, garment bags and selected flexible formats	Can reduce reliance on conventional plastic and support a clearer end-of-life story	Claims must match the exact certification and disposal pathway
Recycled plastic mailers	Brands wanting a lower-cost transition from virgin plastic	Reduces demand for virgin plastic	Still plastic at end of life and may not support the same brand message
Paper / kraft packaging	Dry, flat, lightweight items	Familiar recycling pathway and natural look	Moisture exposure, coatings and durability can be issues
Rigid boxes	Fragile, premium or structured products	Protection and presentation	Higher freight volume and often more material per shipment
Plain stock packaging	Very early-stage brands or urgent dispatch needs	Fast and low commitment	Limited brand impact and less differentiated customer experience

4. Custom Compostable Mailers: The Primary Product

Custom compostable mailers are the most commercially practical starting point for most ecommerce brands looking to move away from conventional plastic packaging.

A mailer is a flexible, sealed pouch designed for shipping. It is what many brands currently use in its conventional plastic form — and custom compostable mailers are designed to replace that format directly.

Why Mailers Are Often the Best First Step

For brands that currently ship goods in standard poly mailers, the switch to custom compostable mailers is a relatively straightforward one. The format is familiar, the operational process is the same, and the visual impact of branding an otherwise plain product can be significant.

Mailers work well for a wide range of product types, particularly:

- Soft goods, garments, and accessories
- Beauty and skincare products in non-fragile packaging
- Folded homeware items, cushion covers, textiles
- Books, stationery, and printed materials
- Wellness products in pouches, sachets, or non-fragile containers
- Jewellery in protective inner packaging
- Gift items, lifestyle accessories, and subscription box items
- Ethical and sustainable product ranges

For these categories, a custom printed compostable mailer gives brands a visible, tangible way to improve the unboxing experience and present their packaging in a way that is consistent with their product quality and values.

What Makes Custom Compostable Mailers Effective

Unlike plain packaging, a custom mailer creates a branded moment. When a customer picks up an order from the doorstep or post box, they see your brand before they open anything. That first impression matters.

Custom compostable mailers from Zero Pack are designed to handle real ecommerce shipping conditions. Depending on the specification chosen, they can offer:

- Waterproof material — protecting products from moisture in transit
- Durable construction — handling the physical demands of courier and postal networks
- Strong adhesive closure — keeping parcels secure from dispatch to delivery
- Custom print — adding your logo, colours, artwork, message, or campaign design

Best Suited For

Product Category	Why Mailers Work Well
Fashion & Apparel	Soft goods fold flat, mailers protect in transit, custom print reinforces brand positioning
Beauty & Skincare	Most products are lightweight and non-fragile, premium mailer print elevates perceived value
Wellness Products	Supplements, accessories, and lifestyle goods ship reliably in mailers
Books & Stationery	Flat items fit mailers well, protection and presentation combined
Gifts & Accessories	Custom print enhances the unboxing experience, important for gifting occasions
Homewares (Soft)	Folded textiles, cushion covers, and fabric goods pack efficiently in mailers
Subscription Boxes	Consistent mailer sizes support repeatable fulfilment processes

Less Suited For

Custom compostable mailers are not the right choice for every product or every business. They are generally less suited for:

- Fragile or breakable items that require rigid protection — these typically need boxes with internal padding
- Heavy or dense products where mailer material strength may be insufficient
- Sharp or angular products that could puncture the mailer material
- Products requiring temperature control or specific protective conditions
- Products that need to arrive visibly box-presented — for example, premium gift boxes or structured retail packaging

If your products fall into these categories, a padded mailer, garment bag, or box-based format may be more appropriate. These are covered in the next section.

5. Other Custom Compostable Packaging Options

While custom compostable mailers are the primary product focus for Zero Pack, there are other compostable packaging formats worth understanding for brands with different product types or distribution needs that are also supplied by Zero Pack.

A. Custom Compostable Shopping Bags

Custom compostable shopping bags are designed for in-store retail use, events, brand activations, market stalls, pop-ups, and gift shops. They are the compostable alternative to the conventional plastic or non-woven shopping bag.

Best suited for:

- Retail stores wanting to provide a branded carry bag at point of purchase
- Brand activations, trade shows, and pop-up events
- Gift shops, boutiques, and artisan market stalls
- Charities distributing branded merchandise or fundraising packs
- Brands running seasonal or campaign-specific packaging

Key benefits:

- Branded and visible — the customer carries your brand through the street
- Compostable alternative to conventional single-use plastic carrier bags
- Customisable in size, colour, and print
- Reinforces sustainability positioning at the point of sale

Things to consider:

- Typically designed for in-store or event use rather than postal or courier shipping
- May require specific certification depending on regional single-use plastics regulations
- Disposal instructions and end-of-life conditions should be clearly communicated

B. Custom Compostable Garment Bags

Custom compostable garment bags are designed for fashion brands, apparel retailers, and businesses shipping or displaying clothing items. They replace the conventional plastic garment cover used in retail fulfilment and dispatch.

Best suited for:

- Fashion brands shipping single garments or sets
- Boutique retailers presenting garments with branded packaging
- Retail fulfilment operations replacing conventional plastic covers
- Brands wanting to protect garments from dust, moisture, and transit damage

Key benefits:

- Purpose-built for garment protection and presentation
- Allows branding to be clearly visible on the packaging
- Compostable alternative to conventional plastic garment covers
- Supports fashion brand sustainability commitments

Things to consider:

- Sizing must be confirmed carefully to ensure the garment fits
- Consider whether a garment bag or a standard mailer better suits your dispatch format
- Confirm material and certification details with Zero Pack before production

C. Custom Compostable Padded Mailers

Padded mailers add a layer of protection for products that need more cushioning than a standard flat mailer provides, but do not need the full rigidity of a box.

Best suited for:

- Electronics accessories, small hardware items, or fragile but non-breakable goods
- Jewellery or small accessories in their own inner packaging
- Beauty or skincare products with glass components that need cushioning
- Products slightly too heavy or firm for a standard mailer

Key benefits:

- Better product protection than a standard flat mailer
- More practical than a full box for certain product shapes and weights
- Brandable with custom print

Important note on compostability:

Padded mailers present more complexity than standard mailers when it comes to compostability claims. The padding layer and the outer material are often different, and the disposal process may be more complex. Always confirm specific material specifications, certification, and disposal guidance with Zero Pack before making any compostability claims about padded mailers.

D. Compostable Layflat Tubing

Compostable layflat tubing is a flexible, roll-based packaging format that allows businesses to cut packaging to the exact length needed for each product. Rather than a fixed bag size, the tubing is sealed at one or both ends and cut to fit.

Best suited for:

- Brands with products of varying lengths, such as rolled textiles, artwork prints, posters, or long garments
- Fulfilment operations that want to reduce packaging waste by sizing each pack to the product
- Businesses packing items manually where flexibility is more important than speed

Key benefits:

- Reduces packaging material waste by eliminating excess bag length

- One material format can cover a wide range of product sizes
- Can reduce storage requirements compared to holding multiple fixed-size bags

Things to consider:

- Requires a heat sealer or appropriate sealing mechanism
- Branding is typically applied to the material roll, so placement may vary
- Confirm material certification and disposal requirements before use

6. Which Packaging Type Is Right for Your Brand?

Use this table to get an initial sense of which packaging format best suits your business needs. These are general guidelines — the right choice will depend on your specific products, shipping volumes, and brand goals.

Packaging Type	Best For	Brand Benefit	Operational Consideration	Best Stage of Business
Custom compostable mailers	Soft goods, fashion, beauty, wellness, gifts, books	Premium brand presentation, strong unboxing moment	MOQ from ~2,000 units; lead time required	Growing brand shipping regular orders
Custom compostable shopping bags	Retail stores, events, boutiques	Visible brand carry, point-of-sale presence	In-store use; not for postal shipping	Retail or event-based businesses
Custom compostable garment bags	Fashion brands, apparel fulfilment	Garment protection with brand visibility	Sizing precision required	Fashion brands with consistent garment SKUs
Custom compostable padded mailers	Small fragile or semi-fragile products	Protection plus branding	Compostability claims need careful verification	Brands with fragile lightweight goods
Compostable layflat tubing	Variable-length products, prints, textiles	Reduces material waste, flexible sizing	Requires sealing equipment	Brands with irregular product lengths
Plain packaging with stickers	Early-stage brands testing the market	Low cost, fast setup	Less premium impression	Pre-launch or very early stage
Conventional plastic mailers	Any product type	Low cost, widely available	Increasingly misaligned with brand and customer expectations	Not recommended for brand-led businesses
Recycled plastic mailers	Any product type	Lower virgin plastic use	Still plastic; limited branding differentiation	Transitional step, not a long-term brand solution

Paper / kraft mailers or bags	Lightweight flat items, books, documents	Natural aesthetic; paper recycling pathway	Less durable; moisture exposure risk	Brands with dry, flat, non-fragile products
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Zero Pack Focus

Zero Pack's primary strength is custom compostable mailers. If this is your most relevant format, you are in the right place. For other compostable packaging formats, Zero Pack can help you understand what options are available and whether they suit your product and business requirements.

7. When Is the Right Time to Switch?

Switching to custom compostable packaging is not the right move for every business at every stage. This section is designed to help you assess whether now is the right time — and if it is not, what to do first.

Signs You Are Ready

A business may be well-placed to make the switch if most of the following are true:

- You ship regular orders — ideally over a hundred or more per month.
- You have a clear brand identity, including a logo and brand colours.
- You want your packaging to look more professional and brand-aligned.
- You have received questions from customers about your packaging.
- You want to reduce your reliance on conventional plastic packaging.
- You can realistically use 2,000 units or more within a two-year timeframe.
- Your products have a consistent size and weight that suits a standard mailer format.
- You have, or can create, artwork and logo files for print.
- You want packaging that supports your premium or sustainable positioning.
- You are preparing for a product launch, rebrand, retail partnership, or growth phase.

Signs You May Not Be Ready Yet

Switching may be premature if several of the following apply:

- You only need a few hundred units — the economics of custom production will not work at that volume.
- Your branding is still evolving and likely to change in the short term.
- Your product range does not yet have consistent sizes.
- You need packaging immediately — custom production requires lead time.
- You are primarily making a decision based on finding the cheapest option.
- You have not yet validated demand or have unpredictable order volumes.
- You cannot forecast how many units you will use in the next three to six months.

A Helpful Reframe

Not being ready now is not a permanent state. Many brands that are not yet ready for custom compostable packaging simply need to consolidate their branding, reach a consistent order volume, or clarify their product range first. If that is where you are, the most useful step is to get clear on what needs to happen before custom packaging becomes viable.

Zero Pack is happy to have that conversation. Sometimes the most useful outcome of an initial enquiry is a clear picture of what to do first.

8. The Commercial Case for Custom Compostable Packaging

It would be a mistake to treat custom compostable packaging purely as an environmental decision. The commercial arguments are just as strong — and in many cases, more immediately relevant to a business's growth.

Better First Impressions

Packaging is the first physical touchpoint after purchase. A well-designed, branded compostable mailer makes that moment feel considered, professional, and intentional. For businesses that have invested in product quality, branding, and marketing, custom packaging brings the physical experience in line with everything else.

Stronger Customer Experience

Customer experience does not end when the purchase is confirmed. For ecommerce brands, the arrival of an order is one of the highest-attention moments in the customer relationship. Packaging that looks right, feels right, and reflects the brand's quality standard strengthens that experience. Packaging that does not can quietly erode it.

Higher Perceived Value

There is a consistent relationship between how professional packaging looks and how customers perceive the product inside. Custom branded packaging raises perceived value — not by changing what is in the box, but by signalling that the brand is serious about every aspect of the customer experience.

A Repeat Brand Touchpoint

Every order sent is an opportunity for a brand to show up consistently. Custom mailers turn a functional process — shipping — into a branded moment that happens reliably, at scale, with every dispatch.

Social Media and Unboxing

A well-designed custom mailer is far more likely to be photographed, shared, or mentioned by customers than a plain plastic bag. For brands in lifestyle, fashion, beauty, or gift categories, the unboxing moment has become a genuine marketing channel. Packaging that looks good in a photo is packaging that can work harder than its unit cost suggests.

Loyalty and Brand Alignment

Customers who care about sustainability — and many do — notice when a brand's packaging aligns with the values the brand communicates. Consistency between what a brand says and what it ships builds trust. Inconsistency creates friction.

Support for Premium Positioning

For brands at the premium end of their category, plain plastic packaging creates a visual mismatch that can undermine pricing confidence. Custom compostable packaging signals quality, care, and brand intentionality — all of which support the case for buying at a higher price point.

9. The Sustainability Case

Custom compostable packaging can be a meaningful step forward from conventional plastic mailers — but it is worth being accurate about what that means in practice.

Reducing Reliance on Conventional Plastic

The primary sustainability benefit of certified compostable packaging is that it helps brands reduce reliance on conventional petroleum-derived plastic and, where the right conditions exist, provides a clearer composting pathway at end of life.

For brands that currently use conventional plastic mailers, switching to certified compostable alternatives can be a genuine and credible improvement. It is not a claim to have solved every packaging challenge, but it can be a practical step in a better direction.

Supporting a Clearer Sustainability Story

Many brands make sustainability commitments that are not yet fully reflected in their packaging choices. Switching to custom compostable packaging helps close that gap. It gives brands something specific and tangible to communicate: a move away from conventional plastic that customers can see and verify.

Compostability Depends on Several Factors

The actual environmental benefit of compostable packaging depends on more than the material it is made from. Key factors include:

- Whether the material is certified for home composting or industrial composting
- Whether the customer has access to appropriate disposal conditions
- Whether clear disposal instructions are provided on or with the packaging
- Whether the material actually reaches a composting environment rather than landfill

Brands should be honest about these limitations when communicating their packaging choices to customers. Compostable packaging is better than conventional plastic in the right conditions — but the right conditions are not automatically guaranteed by the material alone.

Not All 'Eco' Packaging Claims Are Equal

One of the most important things brands can do when switching to compostable packaging is to understand what they are claiming — and make sure those claims are accurate, specific, and defensible.

The packaging industry uses a lot of overlapping and frequently misunderstood terminology. Below is a plain-language explanation of the most common terms.

Term	What It Actually Means
Compostable	Designed to break down into non-toxic components under composting conditions. The key variable is which composting conditions — home or industrial.
Home compostable	Designed to break down in a domestic compost bin or heap, without requiring industrial processing. Generally, requires more time than industrial composting.
Industrial compostable	Requires high-temperature industrial composting conditions to break down correctly. Will not break down effectively in a home compost bin or typical soil conditions.
Biodegradable	Will break down eventually through biological processes — but there is no standard timeframe, no required conditions, and no regulation on this claim in many markets. A very vague term that can mean almost anything and often used in greenwashing.
Oxo-degradable	Conventional plastic with chemical additives that cause it to fragment into smaller pieces over time. These fragments are still plastic. Oxo-degradable packaging is widely considered a misleading greenwashing environmental claim and is banned in some regions.
Recyclable	Can be processed through the appropriate recycling waste stream. However, recyclability depends on local infrastructure, consumer behaviour, and contamination. A product being technically recyclable does not guarantee it will be recycled.
Recycled plastic	Made from post-consumer or post-industrial plastic waste. Still plastic at end of life. A meaningful reduction in virgin plastic use, but not a compostable or zero-waste solution.
Paper / kraft packaging	Paper-based packaging. Can often be recycled or composted depending on coatings, inks, and laminates. Not inherently plastic-free — some paper packaging has plastic coatings.

10. Certification and Avoiding Greenwashing

One of the most important things a brand can do when switching to compostable packaging is to make sure the claims it makes are accurate, specific, and backed by evidence.

Greenwashing — using vague or misleading environmental claims to present a more sustainable image than the facts support — is both a commercial risk and an ethical one. Customers who discover that a sustainability claim is exaggerated or inaccurate are likely to feel misled. Regulatory bodies in many markets are also taking an increasingly close interest in environmental claims.

Why Certification Matters

Certification provides external, independent validation that a material meets a defined compostability standard. It is the difference between a supplier saying a product is compostable and a third-party body confirming it has been tested and meets a recognised standard.

The most commonly referenced compostability certifications include industrial composting and home composting standards. These vary by region and the specific certification scheme used. When asking about certification for any packaging product, ask for the specific standard the material meets, not just confirmation that it is compostable.

Why 'Biodegradable' Alone Is Not Enough

The word 'biodegradable' is one of the most widely misused terms in packaging. It has no standard definition, no regulated timeframe, and no required testing in most markets. Almost everything will eventually break down in some form, but that does not mean it breaks down safely, quickly, or without leaving plastic fragments behind.

Brands should not use 'biodegradable' as a primary packaging claim unless they can be specific about what that means, under what conditions, and in what timeframe. If a supplier uses 'biodegradable' as their primary claim without being able to answer those questions, that is a signal to probe further before committing.

Home Compostable vs Industrial Compostable

This is one of the most important distinctions for brands to understand before choosing a compostable packaging product and communicating its properties to customers.

Industrial compostable packaging requires conditions that most domestic customers cannot replicate. If packaging needs to go to an industrial composting facility to break down, customers need to know that — and have access to those facilities. If the product instead ends up in general waste or garden compost, it may not break down as intended.

Home compostable packaging is designed for conditions that more customers can achieve — a domestic compost bin or heap. However, home compostable products tend to have different material specifications and may perform differently in transit or storage conditions.

Neither is universally better. The right choice depends on your material needs, your customer base, and what disposal guidance you can realistically provide.

Better Claim Language

Here are examples of how to improve common packaging claims to make them more accurate and defensible:

Weaker Claim (avoid)	Stronger Claim (use instead)
100% eco-friendly packaging	Compostable packaging designed to help reduce reliance on conventional plastic.
Planet-safe mailers	Custom compostable mailers made for brands moving away from conventional plastic.
Completely guilt-free packaging	A better packaging choice for brands that want to reduce plastic waste.
Saves the planet	Supports your brand's move to lower-waste packaging.
Fully sustainable packaging	Compostable packaging that replaces conventional plastic mailers in your dispatch process.
Zero impact packaging	A more considered packaging option with a clearer end-of-life pathway than conventional plastic.

What to Ask Your Packaging Supplier

Before placing an order, ask:

- What specific compostability certification does this material carry?
- Is it home compostable or industrial compostable?
- What certification standard and certification body applies?
- What disposal instructions should we provide to customers?
- Are there regional differences in composting infrastructure I should be aware of?

A good supplier will answer these questions directly and specifically.

Certification Standards at a Glance

Certification standards vary by region and by product. A supplier should be able to identify the exact standard, the certification body, and whether the certificate applies to the specific packaging format being quoted.

Important note: this guide is general information. Packaging rules, environmental claims law, composting access and labelling expectations vary by market. Always check the requirements that apply in the countries where your packaging will be sold, shipped and disposed of.

Standard / Scheme	Common Use	What It Indicates	Important Note
AS5810	Home compostable packaging, commonly referenced in Australia	Tested for home composting conditions	Product-specific; ask for evidence that applies to the exact material
AS4736	Industrial compostable packaging in Australia	Designed for industrial composting conditions	Not the same as home compostable
EN 13432/TUV OK Compost Industrial	Industrial compostable packaging in Europe/UK contexts	Compostable under defined industrial conditions	Requires appropriate facility access
TUV OK compost HOME	Home compostability certification used internationally	Designed for lower-temperature home composting conditions	Check certificate scope and product coverage
ASTM D6400 / D6868	Commonly referenced in the United States	Compostability testing for plastics/coated materials	Often linked with BPI certification in market claims
Supplier claim only	Unverified marketing language	No independent proof by itself	Treat as a red flag until documentation is provided

11. Cost, MOQ, and Value

Understanding the economics of custom compostable packaging is important before you start the ordering process. The numbers are straightforward once you know what you are looking at.

Why Custom Packaging Has MOQs

MOQ stands for minimum order quantity. It exists in custom packaging because each order requires a specific production run: your artwork is set up, your material is cut, your printing is calibrated to your specifications. That setup process has a fixed cost regardless of how many units are produced.

Custom packaging is not the same as buying pre-made stock bags. Every run is made specifically for your brand, your size, and your print requirements. MOQs reflect the minimum quantity at which that production run is commercially viable.

A Practical Starting Point

For many brands, a starting MOQ of around 2,000 units is a realistic entry point for custom compostable packaging. That number may vary depending on the packaging type, size, and specification.

For context: if a brand ships 200 orders per month, 2,000 units represents approximately a 10-month supply. If it ships 500 orders per month, that same quantity lasts around four months. Planning ahead is important — both to justify the unit economics and to avoid running out of stock between production runs.

Why Unit Cost Improves at Higher Volumes

Custom packaging follows standard manufacturing economics: the more you order, the lower your cost per unit. The setup cost is spread across a larger production volume, which reduces the unit price.

This is worth factoring into your planning. A larger first order — if you have the confidence in your usage and the storage capacity — will typically deliver a better unit cost than the minimum order.

The Right Way to Think About Packaging Cost

The unit cost of a custom compostable mailer is almost always higher than the unit cost of a generic conventional plastic bag. This is a straightforward fact.

The more useful question is not simply 'what does this mailer cost per unit?' but rather:

A Better Cost Question
What does this packaging help my brand communicate every time an order arrives?

A custom compostable mailer is not just a shipping cost. It is a brand touchpoint. It reinforces your visual identity. It improves the customer experience. It can reduce the gap between how premium your product is and how premium your packaging looks. It supports your sustainability story. It can be photographed and shared.

When you account for all of those factors, the difference in unit cost between a generic plastic bag and a branded compostable mailer looks quite different.

Comparing Packaging Options by Value, Not Just Price

Factor	Conventional Plastic	Recycled Plastic	Custom Compostable
Unit cost	Low	Low to medium	Medium to higher
Brand presentation	None (generic)	Limited	Full custom print
Unboxing experience	Forgettable	Forgettable	Memorable
Sustainability story	Weak	Moderate	Strong (with certification)
Customer perception	Commodity	Commodity	Considered brand
Social media value	Negligible	Negligible	Meaningful
Alignment with premium positioning	Poor	Poor-moderate	Good

12. Artwork, Size, and Specification

Custom packaging requires more preparation than ordering from stock. The more clarity you bring to your initial enquiry, the faster and smoother the quoting and production process will be.

What You Need Before Requesting a Quote

Before contacting Zero Pack for a quote, it helps to have the following information ready or at least roughly defined:

- **Logo files:** Ideally in vector format (.ai, .eps, or high-resolution .pdf). If you only have a JPG or PNG, let the team know — this can often still be worked with.

- **Brand colours:** Pantone references if available, or HEX codes. This helps ensure your print colours are accurate.
- **Preferred mailer size:** Width x height in millimetres or centimetres. If you do not know your exact size, measuring your most common products and allowing appropriate clearance will get you to a working estimate.
- **Quantity:** How many units you want to order. If you are unsure, start with your expected usage over six to twelve months and up to two years.
- **Number of print colours:** Single colour print (e.g. logo only) costs less than multi-colour or full-surface printing. Have a rough sense of what you want before quoting.
- **Delivery country:** Production and shipping logistics vary by region.
- **Product type being shipped:** Knowing what goes in the mailer helps confirm the right material and size.
- **Artwork or design direction:** A finished design is ideal, but even a rough direction — colours, layout, key messages — helps scope the quote.
- **Timeline:** When do you need the packaging? Custom production requires lead time, so working backwards from your required date is important.
- **Whether you use a 3PL:** Third-party logistics providers may have specific packaging requirements. It is worth checking before ordering.

Choosing the Right Size

Size selection is one of the most important practical decisions in custom packaging. The right mailer should fit the majority of your products with enough room to close the adhesive strip securely, but without excess material that creates a loose, unprofessional presentation.

If your products vary in size, consider ordering one or two sizes that cover most orders, rather than trying to match every product with a perfectly sized mailer. A small range of sizes is easier to manage than a wide one.

When in doubt, Zero Pack can advise on size selection based on the products you describe.

Print Quality and Artwork

Custom packaging printing typically requires print-ready artwork or vector files. If you are working with a graphic designer, let them know you need print-ready files for custom packaging — they will understand the requirements.

If you do not have a designer and need guidance on preparing artwork, the Zero Pack team can advise on what is needed and what options exist.

Before You Request a Quote: Checklist

✓	Item
	Logo file in vector or high-resolution format
	Brand colour codes (Pantone, HEX, or CMYK)
	Preferred mailer size or product dimensions
	Quantity needed
	Estimated print colours
	Delivery country confirmed
	Product type noted
	Artwork ready or design direction described
	Required by date identified
	3PL requirements checked (if applicable)

13. Lead Times and Reorder Planning

Custom compostable packaging is made to order. That means there is a production lead time between placing an order and receiving finished packaging. Understanding and planning for this is one of the most practical things a brand can do to avoid operational stress. Depending on your location it can take between eight to twelve weeks to receive delivery of custom packaging.

Custom Packaging Is Not Off-the-Shelf

Generic stock packaging — available from many wholesale suppliers — can often be ordered and delivered within a few days. Custom compostable packaging does not work the same way.

Each order involves artwork confirmation, material preparation, printing, production, quality checking, and dispatch. That process takes time. The exact lead time will depend on the order size, the complexity of the artwork, and the production schedule at the time of ordering.

For this reason, Zero Pack asks brands to factor lead times into their planning from the start. Confirming the required delivery date early in the quoting conversation is always worthwhile.

Reorder Before You Run Out

Many brands that manage stock packaging well still run out at the wrong moment because they treat packaging reorders differently from product reorders. A stock-out of custom compostable mailers at a peak shipping period can force a return to plain or plastic packaging — and undo the operational and brand investment made in switching.

A simple rule: reorder when you have used roughly half your stock, not when you are nearly empty. This gives you adequate buffer against any production or logistics delays without requiring you to hold excessive inventory.

Planning Around Peaks and Launches

If your business has seasonal peaks — such as Christmas, end-of-financial-year gifting, product launches, or campaign periods — plan your packaging order to arrive well before those periods. A new product launch is not the time to discover your custom packaging has a eight-week lead time.

Think about:

- When are your highest-volume shipping periods?
- What is your average monthly usage at normal and peak volumes?
- How far in advance do you need to place a reorder to maintain continuity?

Forecasting Usage

A simple way to forecast packaging usage is to look at your average monthly order volume and multiply by how many months of stock you want to hold. Building in a modest buffer for growth is sensible.

For example: if you ship 300 orders per month and want three months of stock, you need approximately 900 units as a working minimum. If your MOQ is 2,000 units, that order would give you approximately six to seven months of stock — which is a comfortable operational position.

14. How to Choose Your First Custom Mailer

Ordering custom packaging for the first time can feel more complicated than it needs to be. These principles are designed to help you make a confident, practical first decision.

Start With Your Most Common Size

Rather than trying to cover every product in your range with a perfectly fitted mailer, focus on the size that will work for the majority of your orders. One well-chosen size is more useful than three sizes that create inventory management complexity.

Measure your most commonly shipped products, add appropriate clearance for folding and closure, and use that as the basis for your first size selection.

Keep the Artwork Clear and Recognisable

Custom packaging does not need to be complex to be effective. A clean logo, strong brand colours, and one or two clear messages will almost always outperform an over-designed mailer that is difficult to read or visually cluttered.

The goal of the first run is to establish a branded, credible packaging presence. You can develop more sophisticated designs in subsequent orders once you have seen how the base format works.

In many markets, compostability claims need clear supporting information. When planning your design, leave space to state whether the packaging is home compostable or industrial compostable, what certification applies, and how customers should dispose of it. If you are unsure what wording is appropriate, the Zero Pack team can help you prepare clearer disposal guidance before production.

Choose Quantity Based on Realistic Usage

Order a quantity that reflects your realistic usage forecast — not your aspirational shipping volume. A 2,000-unit order that takes 12 months to use is not a problem. An order you exceed in two months and then scramble to replace is.

Think About the Customer Moment

Before confirming your artwork, ask: when this mailer arrives at my customer's door, what does it communicate? The most effective custom packaging creates a moment that feels intentional and considered — not just functional.

Think about:

- What does the customer see first when they pick up the parcel?
- Is the logo and brand identity immediately clear?
- Does the packaging feel consistent with the quality of the product inside?
- Is there any messaging or disposal guidance that should be included?

Include Disposal Guidance

If your packaging is compostable, include clear information on how to dispose of it correctly. This does not need to be complex — a short line on the packaging noting that it is compostable, and what conditions are needed, is a meaningful addition.

It also protects your sustainability claim. Packaging described as compostable but without any disposal guidance leaves customers without the information they need to make the packaging behave as intended.

Ask for Help

Zero Pack's process is designed to guide you through sizing, specification, and artwork requirements. The quoting conversation is also a practical consultation. You do not need to have every answer before you reach out.

15. Decision Checklist: Are You Ready for Custom Compostable Packaging?

Work through the questions below. Each 'yes' answer scores one point.

Question		Yes / No
☐	Do you ship at over one hundred orders per month?	
☐	Can you realistically use 2,000 units or more within two years?	
☐	Do you have stable, established branding (logo, colours, visual identity)?	
☐	Do you know your most common packaging size?	
☐	Do you want packaging to improve brand perception and customer experience?	
☐	Do you care about your sustainability positioning with customers?	
☐	Are you ready to plan three to six weeks ahead for production and delivery?	
☐	Do you want to reduce your reliance on conventional plastic packaging?	
☐	Do you have, or can you create, print-ready artwork or logo files?	
☐	Is your product range reasonably consistent in size and weight?	

Score	What It Means
0 – 3	Start with simple improvements. Focus on clarifying your branding, validating order volumes, and confirming product sizing before investing in custom packaging.
4 – 6	You are moving in the right direction. Address the remaining gaps — most likely around volume, artwork, or size consistency — and then revisit. A conversation with Zero Pack may help clarify what to prepare.
7 – 10	You are ready to request a quote. You have the foundation in place to make custom compostable packaging a worthwhile investment. Reach out to Zero Pack and start the conversation.

16. Common Mistakes to Avoid

Brands new to custom packaging tend to encounter the same challenges. Knowing these in advance can save time, cost, and frustration.

Ordering too many sizes at once

Start with one or two sizes that cover the majority of your orders. A wide size range creates inventory complexity and higher reorder thresholds. Consolidate first, expand later.

Choosing the cheapest option without checking quality

The cheapest custom compostable mailer is not always the best fit. Material quality, waterproofing, adhesive strength, and print quality all vary. Ask for samples before committing to a large production run.

Using vague compostability claims

Saying packaging is 'compostable' without specifying what that means, under what conditions, and what certification applies is a greenwashing risk. Be specific.

Forgetting disposal instructions

Compostable packaging without disposal guidance is an incomplete sustainability claim. Customers need to know what to do with the packaging for it to behave as intended.

Not checking artwork requirements before design

Print-ready artwork has specific requirements. Designing first and asking about specs later can mean expensive redesign work. Ask what is needed before you start, or use Zero Pack's guidance as a brief for your designer.

Leaving reorders too late

Custom packaging requires lead time. If you wait until you are nearly out of stock before reordering, you risk a gap in supply. Reorder at around 50% of remaining stock.

Not checking product fit before ordering

Measure your products before specifying a mailer size. A mailer that is too small is unusable. A mailer that is excessively large looks unprofessional and wastes material.

Assuming all compostable packaging is the same

Materials, certifications, and disposal requirements vary significantly. Two products both described as 'compostable' may require completely different conditions to break down. Understand what you are buying before you claim what it does.

Choosing packaging that does not match brand positioning

Custom packaging should feel consistent with your product quality and brand values. A premium product deserves premium packaging. A mismatched design or material quality can undermine the positioning you have worked to build.

Treating packaging only as a cost

Every mailer you send is a brand touchpoint. The cost per unit is one variable. What that unit communicates to every customer who receives it is another — and often a more commercially important one.

17. Frequently Asked Questions

What is custom compostable packaging?

Custom compostable packaging is packaging made from plant-based materials designed to break down under composting conditions, produced to your brand's specifications — your logo, colours, size, and print design. Rather than ordering generic stock packaging, you receive packaging made specifically for your brand and your products.

What is the minimum order quantity?

For most custom compostable mailers, the starting point is around 2,000 units. The exact MOQ can vary depending on the packaging type, size, and specification. Zero Pack can provide guidance on the most practical quantity for your order during the quoting process.

Are compostable mailers strong enough for ecommerce shipping?

Yes — when produced to appropriate specifications. Zero Pack's compostable mailers are designed for real ecommerce use. Depending on the specification chosen, they can be waterproof, durable, and finished with a strong adhesive closure. The specific product being shipped and the required level of protection should always be confirmed before quoting.

Can I print my logo and brand colours?

Yes. Custom compostable mailers from Zero Pack can be printed with your logo, brand colours, artwork, or campaign design. The print specification — number of colours, print area, artwork format — will be confirmed as part of the quoting process.

Is compostable packaging more expensive than conventional plastic?

On a per-unit basis, yes. Custom compostable packaging typically costs more than generic conventional plastic mailers. The value difference comes from the custom branding, the material quality, the better alignment with customer expectations, and the reduction in conventional plastic use — all of which have commercial and brand implications beyond the unit cost.

Is home compostable better than industrial compostable?

Not automatically. Home compostable packaging can be disposed of in more accessible conditions — a domestic compost bin — but it may have different material performance characteristics. Industrial compostable packaging typically requires specific facility conditions but may offer different material properties. The right choice depends on your specific product needs and what disposal guidance you can provide customers. Zero Pack can advise on the options available.

Can compostable packaging go in the recycling bin?

Generally, no. Compostable packaging is not the same as recyclable packaging and should not be placed in standard recycling bins. It is designed for composting conditions, not the recycling waste stream. Always include clear disposal instructions on or with your packaging.

How long does custom packaging take?

Custom packaging is made to order and requires production lead time. The exact lead time will depend on the order size, print complexity, and production schedule. This is confirmed during the quoting process. Planning ahead — especially ahead of seasonal peaks or product launches — is strongly recommended.

What products are compostable mailers best suited for?

Custom compostable mailers work best for soft, lightweight, non-fragile goods. Fashion and apparel, beauty and skincare, wellness products, books, stationery, accessories, gifts, and lifestyle items are common fits. Products that are fragile, sharp, heavy, or require rigid protection may need a different packaging format.

What do I need before requesting a quote?

Ideally: your logo files, brand colour references, a preferred mailer size or product dimensions, estimated quantity, delivery country, and a rough sense of your artwork or design direction. If you are missing some of these, Zero Pack can help you work through them. You do not need everything finalised before making initial contact.

Should a small business switch to custom compostable packaging?

It depends on where the business is. If you are shipping several hundred orders per month, have consistent branding, and can meet a practical MOQ, custom packaging can make strong commercial sense. If you are at an earlier stage — lower volumes, evolving branding, no consistent product range — it is worth building those foundations first and revisiting when the time is right.

How do I avoid greenwashing with compostable packaging?

Be specific in your claims. Know whether your packaging is home compostable or industrial compostable. Know what certification it carries. Provide clear disposal instructions. Avoid vague language like '100% eco-friendly' or 'completely guilt-free'. A specific, supported claim is always more credible than a broad environmental statement.

What packaging format should I choose?

Start with the format that fits the majority of your products. For most ecommerce brands shipping soft goods, a custom compostable mailer is the most practical and commercially effective starting point. For retail carry bags, garment bags, or products requiring extra protection, other formats may be more appropriate. Zero Pack can help you identify the right option for your product range.

Can I use compostable packaging with a 3PL?

Yes, in most cases. Third-party logistics providers can typically handle custom compostable mailers as they would any other mailer format. It is worth checking your 3PL's specific requirements — particularly around packaging dimensions, closure type, and any labelling needs — before finalising your order specification.

18. Ready to Replace Conventional Plastic Packaging?

If you have worked through this guide and reached the conclusion that custom compostable packaging is the right next step for your brand, Zero Pack is here to help you make it happen.

The process starts with a conversation. Tell us what you ship, how you ship it, and what you want your packaging to communicate — and we will help you work through the right format, size, specification, and quote.

What Zero Pack Can Help You With

- Choosing the right mailer format and size for your products
- Understanding what material and specification suits your shipping conditions
- Working through artwork requirements and print options
- Preparing a clear and detailed custom quote
- Planning your first order around your volume, timeline, and budget
- Thinking through compostability claims and disposal guidance

Get Started

Visit www.zeropack.co to request a custom quote.

If you are ready to replace plain or plastic-heavy packaging with custom compostable mailers made for your brand, Zero Pack can help you work through the right size, quantity, artwork, and quote.

You do not need to have everything figured out before reaching out. That is what the quoting conversation is for.

Zero Pack | Custom compostable packaging for brands that care.
www.zeropack.co